# Tim Leffler

Munich Graduate School of Economics

**Primary field:** Applied Microeconomics
**Secondary fields:** Political Economy, Economics of Education
**Research topics:** Political Behavior, Inequality, Human Capital, Digital Skill, NLP, Multimodal Data

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## REFERENCES

**Prof. Dr. Florian Englmaier**
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**Prof. Dr. Fabian Kosse**
University of Würzburg
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## EDUCATION

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|---|---|---|
| Expected 2027 | **PhD in Economics** | LMU Munich |
| Sept.–Nov. 2026 | **Research Visit**, Elliott Ash's AI & Economics Lab | ETH Zurich |
| June 2024 | **Research Visit**, Nicola Lacetera | University of Toronto |
| March–May 2024 | **Research Visit**, John List's research group | University of Chicago |
| 2017–2020 | **MSc Economics** | University of Bonn |
| 2013–2017 | **BSc Economics** | University of Bonn |
| 2015–2016 | **Study Abroad** (PROMOS Scholarship) | National Chengchi University, Taiwan |

**Funding:** Jacobs Foundation Scholarship (Sept. 2020–Aug. 2021); CRC TRR 190 research visits (2024).

## JOB MARKET PAPER

### Facing the Far Right, or Looking Away? Video Evidence from Parliament latest version

Confronting a far-right party can lend it standing; ignoring it leaves its claims unanswered. We study how established legislators allocate public attention to a far-right challenger once they must work alongside it. From more than 23,000 German Bundestag speeches with video, audio, and text aligned word by word, we measure engagement with the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD) after its 2017 entry: whether a speech names the party, and whether the speaker turns toward its benches. Identification comes from an indivisibility in the rule that allocates committee seats, which varies how many AfD colleagues a legislator works with, across 9,376 speeches by 269 legislators who kept a committee through the 2017 election. Across the full range of exposure, engagement falls by 0.41 standard deviations; the probability that a speech names the AfD falls from 35 to 24 percent, about 8.5 percentage points per additional AfD colleague on a committee of average size. The decline is concentrated in negatively worded mentions, and naming of the established parties does not move. Working alongside the challenger reduces the public attention established legislators direct at it.

## OTHER WORKING PAPERS

### Digital Skills: Social Disparities and the Impact of Early Mentoring

with Fabian Kosse and Arna Woemmel; *Revise and Resubmit at Research Policy*; CESifo Working Paper No. 11570

We investigate social disparities in digital skills, focusing on both actual proficiency levels and confidence in these skills. Drawing on a representative sample from Germany, we first demonstrate that both dimensions strongly predict labor market success. We then use this sample to identify gender and socioeconomic disparities in levels and confidence. Finally, using a long-run RCT panel framework with young adults, we confirm these disparities and provide causal evidence on the effects of enhancing the social environment in childhood. Assigning elementary school-aged children to a mentoring program persistently reduces socioeconomic gaps in confidence related to digital skills, but it does not affect the level of digital skills.

**Accommodation of Right-Wing Populist Rhetoric: Evidence from Parliamentary Speeches in Germany**

with Emilio Esguerra, Felix Hagemeister, and Julian Heid; CRC TRR 190 Discussion Paper No. 435

We provide novel evidence on how right-wing (populist) rhetoric spreads. Using several thousand speeches from the German parliament, we show that exposure to politicians from the right-wing populist Alternative for Germany (AfD) leads mainstream politicians to adopt a more distinctively right-wing populist language. We measure similarity to right-wing populist rhetoric via cosine similarity to both parliamentary speeches by the AfD and extremist speeches at far-right rallies, as well as using a populist dictionary method. To induce individual-level variation in exposure to AfD politicians, we exploit a quasi-exogenous allocation rule for committee members in the German parliament. Comparing a politician with the highest to one with the lowest relative AfD exposure increases the cosine similarity to right-wing populist speech by 0.1 of a standard deviation. Our results seem specific to right-wing populism and suggest strategic motives related to local electoral competition behind rhetorical changes among individual politicians.

## WORK IN PROGRESS

**Who Looks Up to Whom? Role Model Selection Amongst Teenagers: News Coverage Paired with Natural Language Processing**

with Fabian Kosse

We study how adolescents choose public-figure role models and how news exposure and family background shape those choices.

## PRESENTATIONS

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| 2026 | AI & Economics Lab (ETH Zurich), Verein für Socialpolitik Annual Conference (Innsbruck) |
| 2024 | John List's research group (University of Chicago) |
| 2023 | Economics Brownbag Seminar (invited, University of Würzburg), 5th Annual COMPTEXT Conference (Glasgow), Studi-BUCH Interdisciplinary Text-as-Data Workshop (Essen), NextGenerationEconomics Spring Workshop (Hohenheim/Mannheim), 12th CRC Rationality and Competition Retreat (Berlin) |
| 2022 | CRC Rationality and Competition Young Economist Workshop (Tutzing), HCEO-briq Summer School on Socioeconomic Inequality (poster, Bonn) |

## ACADEMIC SERVICE

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| 2026 | Ad hoc referee, *Management Science* |
| 2023–2024 | Organizer, Interdisciplinary Workshop on Text and Unstructured Data, LMU Munich (three sessions) |

## TEACHING AND SUPERVISION

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Summer 2026 | Data Science in Business and Economics (Undergraduate) | Tutorial |
| 2024–2027 | Empirical and Experimental Behavioral Economics (Undergraduate) | Seminar |
| 2024–2027 | Policy and Management Evaluation Methods (Graduate) | Tutorial |
| 2023–2024 | Research Projects in Empirical Economic Research (Undergraduate) | Seminar |
| 2023–2024 | Macroeconomics for non-econ Bachelors (GVWL2) | Tutorial |
| 2020–2026 | Supervision of 28 theses | |

## RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

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|---|---|---|
| 2024–present | **Research Associate**, Chair of Data Science in Business and Economics | University of Würzburg |
| 2024–present | **Junior Researcher** | C-BEAM |
| 2021–2024 | **Research Affiliate** | CRC TRR 190 Rationality and Competition |
| Jan.–May 2024 | **Research Assistant** | IZA Institute of Labor Economics |
| 2020–2023 | **Research Assistant** | briq Institute on Behavior and Inequality |
| 2017–2020 | **Student Research Assistant** | briq Institute on Behavior and Inequality |

Last updated: November 2026